Ironically – given his efforts to keep them apart – it was Chernenko's funeral that provided a venue for the first meeting between Honecker and the new Federal Chancellor Helmut Kohl at a guest house in the Lenin Hills above Moscow. On that occasion, Honecker also enjoyed a brief chat with Gorbachev who, at 54, was the first Soviet leader to have grown up after the Second World War and the Stalin era.

To begin with, his assumption was viewed positively in East Berlin, despite his announcement at Chernenko's funeral that the Brezhnev Doctrine (the USSR would intervene to save regimes in Eastern Europe) was no longer Soviet policy. However, Gorbachev did extend the validity of the Warsaw Pact treaty for a further twenty-four years, before embarking on his own reform programme to drag the Soviet Union out of political and economic stagnation.

In contrast, Honecker and his administration had become slightly more easy-going. The SED regime's struggle against the ideological competition of the church was replaced by a kind of truce. Not that the church had become 'harmless', it still provided vocal opposition to a multitude of wrongs, especially on issues of pollution and the environment. In international affairs, Honecker, meanwhile, busied himself with a visit to Italy in April, where he met with Pope John Paul II, marking his first state visit to a NATO country. After flying back to Berlin invigorated, any feelings of pride soon evaporated as he became the butt of a joke when newspapers splashed a photo showing him together with the pope. The gag: 'Karl Marx called religion the "opiate of the people", thus Honi [sic] is now in the opium den.'

After a few days at his hunting sanctuary, Honecker was in Athens, then back in Berlin hosting French Prime Minister Laurent Fabius, the first government leader from the three Western Powers to visit the GDR. Honecker also found time to deliver a speech outside the restored Semper